SPOKEN ENGLISH REPERTOIRE BANK

Useful language inside believable speech

IELTS SPEAKING • PART 1

HOW TO USE THIS BANK

Don’t memorise answers. Notice useful language.

1

Read or listen

What does the speaker really mean?

2

Notice the phrase

How does it help the speaker?

3

Make it yours

Could you use it to say something true about yourself?

FREE TIME

I’m really into…

“I’m really into photography at the moment. Nothing professional or anything — I just take photos on my phone when I’m out.”

Whenever I get the chance…

“I go down to the beach whenever I get the chance. Not necessarily to swim or anything — sometimes I’ll just get a coffee and sit there.”

It helps me switch off.

“Usually I’ll put some music on when I get home. It helps me switch off, especially if I’ve had a long day.”

I’ve recently got into…

“I’ve recently got into running, which is weird because I absolutely hated it at school. I’m still pretty slow, but I’m enjoying it.”

HOME & HOMETOWN

It’s nothing fancy, but…

“My flat’s pretty small. It’s nothing fancy, but I’ve got everything I need and the location’s really good.”

There’s not a lot going on.

“It’s a nice town — very quiet, very safe. There’s not a lot going on, though. When I was eighteen I found it incredibly boring.”

It’s got a lot going for it.

“People complain about Manchester because of the weather, but it’s got a lot going for it. The music scene’s great and there’s loads of stuff to do.”

I kind of miss it.

“When I was seventeen I couldn’t wait to leave my hometown. Now I live hundreds of kilometres away and… yeah, weirdly, I kind of miss it.”

WORK & STUDY

What I like most about it is…

“What I like most about my job is the people, actually. The work can get pretty stressful, but the team’s good.”

I’m still getting the hang of…

“I only started using the software a few weeks ago, so I’m still getting the hang of it. I can do the basics now, at least.”

It can get pretty stressful.

“Most of the time I enjoy studying engineering. Around exam time it can get pretty stressful, though.”

I’m hoping to…

“I’m hoping to do a master’s eventually. Not straight away — I think I need a break from studying first.”

FRIENDS & FAMILY

We go way back.

“My closest friend is probably Samir. We go way back — I think we met when we were about six.”

We get on really well.

“I’ve got one older brother and we get on really well now. We fought constantly when we were kids, though.”

We don’t always see eye to eye.

“I’m really close to my dad, although we don’t always see eye to eye, especially when it comes to money.”

I take after…

“I probably take after my mum more than my dad. We’re both quite quiet, whereas my dad will talk to literally anybody.”

FOOD

I’ve got a bit of a sweet tooth.

“I try to eat reasonably well, but I’ve got a bit of a sweet tooth. Put a piece of cheesecake in front of me and it’s basically game over.”

I can’t get enough of…

“At the moment I can’t get enough of Korean food. There’s this little place near my office and I’ve been there, like, three times this week.”

It’s an acquired taste.

“I love really strong black coffee. It’s an acquired taste, I suppose. The first time I tried it I thought it was disgusting.”

I’ll eat pretty much anything.

“I’m not very fussy, honestly. I’ll eat pretty much anything, apart from maybe oysters. I’ve tried. I just can’t.”

TECHNOLOGY & SOCIAL MEDIA

I couldn’t really do without it.

“My phone, probably. I mean, I’d survive obviously, but I couldn’t really do without it for work. Everything’s on there.”

It comes in handy.

“I don’t use my tablet every day, but it comes in handy when I’m travelling. It’s much easier than carrying my laptop around.”

I’m trying to cut down on…

“I’m trying to cut down on social media. I realised I was picking up my phone every five minutes for absolutely no reason.”

I lose track of time.

“That’s the problem with YouTube. I watch one video and then suddenly it’s midnight. I completely lose track of time.”

SHOPPING & MONEY

I tend to shop around.

“If I’m buying something expensive, I tend to shop around first. I hate finding the same thing cheaper five minutes after I’ve bought it.”

It was a bit of an impulse buy.

“I bought a new watch last month. It was a bit of an impulse buy, actually. I went in to buy a charger and somehow came out with a watch.”

It’s good value for money.

“There’s a little restaurant near my house that’s really good value for money. It’s nothing fancy, but the food’s great.”

I’m not really bothered about brands.

“I’m not really bothered about brands. If something looks good and it’s decent quality, I’ll buy it.”

TRAVEL

It’s on my bucket list.

“Japan’s been on my bucket list for years. I keep saying I’m going to go and then something comes up.”

I like getting away from it all.

“Every few months I try to get out of the city for a couple of days. I just like getting away from it all — no traffic, no emails.”

It was well worth the trip.

“It took us nearly six hours to get there because the roads were terrible, but honestly, it was well worth the trip.”

I’d love to go back.

“I went to Istanbul a few years ago and I’d love to go back. I feel like I barely scratched the surface.”

LANGUAGE FOR SPEAKING

These phrases are not about one topic. They help you manage what you mean.

ACTUALLY…

adjust / add something

“I used to hate running, actually. I’m not sure what changed, but now I go three or four times a week.”

I MEAN…

clarify / develop

“I’m not obsessed with my phone. I mean, I use it a lot, obviously, but mostly for work.”

TO BE HONEST…

give a genuine view

“To be honest, I don’t really enjoy shopping. I just want to get what I need and leave.”

IT DEPENDS…

avoid a simple yes / no

“Do I like cooking? It depends, really. If I’ve got time, yeah. After work? No chance.”

EVEN IF…

qualify without changing your main point

“I still enjoy cooking for them, even if they turn their noses up at half the things I make.”

LANGUAGE FOR SPEAKING

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ALTHOUGH… *add a contrast*

“I’m really close to my dad, although we don’t always see eye to eye.”

HAVING SAID THAT… *balance what you just said*

“I’m not a big fan of cities. Having said that, I loved Tokyo.”

YOU KNOW… *assume / build shared understanding*

“It’s difficult sometimes, you know, when everybody’s busy and you’re trying to find a time to meet.”

…RIGHT? *invite the listener to follow your logic*

“They’re my kids, right? I’m still going to love them even if they hate my shawarma.”

I SUPPOSE… *soften / think aloud*

“I suppose the best thing about my hometown is that it still feels familiar, even after all these years.”

MAKE IT YOURS

1. Choose one phrase you could really use.
2. Say something true about yourself.
3. Record it. Listen back.
4. Keep it if it sounds like you.